

WORLD OCEANS DAY 2026

JUNE SPECIAL EDITION - ENDANGERED SPECIES IN WEST AFRICA

Issue 3: Smalltooth Sawfish

The Vanishing Guardian of West Africa's Coastal Waters

The Smalltooth Sawfish (*Pristis pectinata*) is a unique and ancient ray species recognized by its long, saw-like rostrum lined with small teeth. It inhabits shallow coastal and estuarine waters including rivers, lagoons, and mangrove ecosystems along the West African coast.

As a top predator, it helps maintain healthy aquatic ecosystems by regulating prey populations and contributing to the balance of coastal food webs that support fisheries and local livelihoods.



IUCN Status
**CRITICALLY
ENDANGERED**

Major Threats



Smalltooth sawfish distribution across Africa. Compiled by IUCN SSC Shark Specialist Group, 2022



By-catch in fisheries – accidentally caught in gillnets, trawls and longlines targeting other species.

Targeted for its rostrum – the saw is highly valued and traded illegally for use in traditional medicine and decorations.

Habitat loss and degradation – mangrove clearing, pollution, and coastal development destroy critical habitats.

IUU fishing – weak enforcement and unsustainable fishing practices increase pressure on sawfish populations.

Smalltooth Sawfish Conservation is Non-Negotiable

In commemoration of World Oceans Day 2026, WASMaN joins regional and global efforts to protect the smalltooth sawfish. Together, let's:

- ✓ Conserve mangroves, lagoons, and estuaries which are vital nursery and feeding grounds.
- ✓ Promote the use of sawfish-friendly fishing gear and support fishers with best practices.
- ✓ Strengthen regulations and enforcement against the capture, killing and trade of sawfish.
- ✓ Support community education and citizen action to value and protect sawfish.
- ✓ Invest in monitoring and research to inform better conservation and management.